Stop the War from The Syrian Monologues!

Personal Stories of Syrian Refugees in Jordan

By Fatmeh Al Zoubi, translated by Iman Aoun

INTRODUCTION

According to estimates from the Syrian Observatory for Human Rights, more than 600,000 people have been killed since the start of the Syrian Civil war in March 2011.

For nearly 14 years the Syrian people have suffered unimaginable horrors as the government, led by President Bashar al-Assad, perpetrated crimes against humanity and war crimes, brazenly violating international norms and treaties. For millions of Syrians the overthrow of the Assad government by opposition forces in December 2024 presents a historic opportunity to transition away from repression and to potentially reunite with loved ones who fled the country.

As of 2024, the United Nations reports more than 7.4million are currently internally displaced, with more than 6.2 million living as refugees abroad in Jordan, Lebanon, Turkey and Europe.

For Fatmeh Al Zoubi, mother of a 3-year-old with another child on the way, fleeing the al-Assad regime was the only option. In her own words . . . from The Syrian Monologues! Personal Stories of Syrian Refugees in Jordan

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FATMEH: (Pg 10-13) When I used to go to my university exams in Damascus, I would take my child with me. There were many checkpoints on the road and sometimes I wouldn't be able to return home, even though it was only 140 km away. So, I would take him to make sure he's safe. If the soldiers attacked my town, Taher would be with me under my wings. I will be breathing the same air with him, eating the same food together and at night he will be sleeping in my arms peacefully. When I wake up his innocent face will be the first thing I see.

We used to leave at dawn from my hometown Al-Musayfirah to reach Daraa and then Damascus. This journey would take five hours in each direction due to all the imposed checkpoints that were run by either the army or the rebels. When the bus left my town, it carried 14 people including me and my child. After 3km, the first checkpoint and with it the suffering begins; a long and hard waiting time until the checking is over, one car after another until we get our turn. This happens at every checkpoint until we

arrive in Damascus.

[My] little boy knew many war games, especially how to act; yes to act. How can a toddler less than 3 years old act? Taher, my little boy, used to distinguish between checkpoints. He would know which one is for the ***State*** Army and which one for the ***Freedom*** Army. When we were stopped by the ***State*** Army, he would put his little head out of the window and shout: "God, Syria, Bashar only, God protect the army." When the commander heard him, he laughed, approached him and asked: "What's your name? How old are you? Where are you going? Do you love Syria? Do you love Bashar?" And when my son finished answering; the commander would laugh and ask the soldiers to open the checkpoint and give way to the bus.

We were all saved because of him. No one was arrested or asked to show his/her ID card, and we passed quickly. After 40 km, the bus is stopped again at a checkpoint for the ***Freedom*** Army, so Taher started yelling: God, Syria, Freedom only, May God protect the Freedom Army." He did this at every checkpoint we encountered until we arrived in Damascus, and every time the soldiers would laugh and allow us to pass without searching us. This saved his innocence, protected his dreams and guaranteed his mother's way to her exams safely and peacefully.

[But] the clashes accelerated and I had to make the decision to get to a safer place. I decided to leave my country, my family and my dreams. I took my children; one in my arms and the other in my womb; left my house and reached the first point of my immigration saga. I was in Al-Tayba area, still breathing my country's oxygen, walking over its soil and breathing the same air as my loved ones. Every time I heard the sounds of the army's boots and bombs, fear would eat my heart up. I would panic for those I left behind and for those I carry in my arms and in my belly.

I reached the first point of my exodus. We were put in an old house that had cracked walls like our shattered dreams and ruined doors like our torn souls. Its windows were sealed and every time I looked at them, I wondered; would they ever open? Would we

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ever get our freedom? Would the war end? I waited very long before night fell and we were able to leave that house to our escape journey. I forgot my coat in that grim house, I tried to get back for it, but the smuggler refused. I did not want the coat because it was cloudy and the wind was blowing off our bones; I wanted my coat because the smell of my father was still on it. He brought it for me, with tears in his eyes, worried about my unknown future. How I wish to go back to my father's arms.

A woman's voice, about my mother's age, woke me up saying: "Come on, we're starting to walk." I started sobbing and was not able to distinguish between my tears and the rain, as if heaven was embracing my weeping, and the sound of the wind was surrounding the cry of my broken soul. I was terrified; I started asking myself: "What kind of stupid decision I made? Would I reach a safe haven? What would happen if I'm not able to cross over the war zone?" An internal voice cried: "You have promised your child."

The smugglers started to yell: "Stop the babies from crying, they have to sleep so the soldiers won't hear us and attack. Do not talk." I was carrying my child and a small bag filled with his clothes. His brother's heart inside me was beating every minute in my ears. The night was dark and fear was dominating everyone.

One could see the misery in the faces of the worried people. We were 5 men and 6 women with their children. All we were able to hear was our heartbeats filled with fear and the sound of our steps and those of our children, walking slowly and silently. The route was rough, filled with stones and thorns. All of a sudden, we heard the cry of a baby longing for his mother's milk. The smugglers started screaming at the mother: "Hush him, hush him up" and they changed our way into the wood to reduce the sound of the screaming baby. We sat under the trees, while the smugglers covered the mother and the baby with blankets.

We continued our journey. My child was still in my arms. I started to feel his weight getting heavier. My body was collapsing. We arrived at the high hill that we had to

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cross. A man came through the darkness, covering his face with the Syrian flag, and told me: “You have to climb the hill.” I said: “I cannot, I’m pregnant.” His tone changed: “Why didn’t you tell me?” He took my child and we crossed over the hill, our feet stumbling towards the Jordanian border.

The sound of the children’s footsteps during our journey is still alive in my memory. Their steps scattered and scared, yet light and innocent like their dreams, in the beginning. . .

To all the leaders of the world: Stop the war in my country. Stop the bleeding, stop it.

I hereby declare in all the languages of the world: I miss my country, my home, and my children. I miss my university that used to feed my knowledge.

Stop the war.

I miss the walls of my destroyed house, my broken mirrors, and my scattered furniture. I miss the ground in front of my door and the flowers planted in my garden.

Stop the war, the destruction and the killing.

I miss the dream of my country that was shredded by the wounds, the pain and the war. I miss my memories, my happiness, and my wishes. I miss 25 years I spent in my country.

Stop the war, stop the massacres; I’ve been waiting too long on the pathways of hope and in the alleys of dreams. Stop the war.

I ***want*** to miss the sounds of missiles and tanks.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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